CHAPTER 46

TAILENDERS

Before we leave for the Ashes tour of 2017–18, I get a call from Greg James, the presenter of BBC Radio 1's flagship breakfast show, asking if I'd like to do a new podcast with him called *Tailenders* for the BBC. I'd really enjoyed working with Greg and producer Mark 'Sharky' Sharman on a show we had done previously alongside Swanny called *Not Just Cricket*, so I say, of course. He says he's got Felix White from the band The Maccabees involved, a band that Swanny and I had raced from an abandoned South Africa one-day game to go and see at Reading Festival a few years earlier. The Maccabees have just split and Felix loves cricket, and Greg thinks it will work. Sounds good, I say, expecting us to do a few episodes while I'm in Australia.

A few episodes in, I'm taken by surprise by how much I'm enjoying it. Speaking to people who have seen me play from the outside and are so clearly passionate about the game helps me to see my career through a new lens. At first, I'm amazed the episodes come out so well and are so warmly received. To me, they seem like general rambling chats that I assume are barely serviceable as a BBC podcast, but it appears our style of casually presenting cricket from every aspect has connected with people very quickly. Callers get in touch with the show every week, spinning us into conversations away from the current Ashes series that's in progress and more towards how cricket lives in the imagination. These conversations open something up in myself. I end up realising that cricket has infiltrated my system so much that when I walk over a pavement slab, and my foot is over the crack, I'll think to myself, *Shit, no ball*. People phone in to tell us about playing all kinds of different cricket in their sixties or even older too. It begins to inspire me again to notice that cricket is such a portal for